Pandalai and Prof. Narasingha Rao. Each one of them had very distinct personalities, but they shared a common impulse— the capacity to feed their students' intel ectual hunger by sheer bril iance and untiring zeal.

Prof. Sponder taught me technical aerodynamics. He was an Austrian with rich practical experience in aeronautical engineering. During the Second World War, he had been captured by the Nazis and imprisoned in a concentration camp. Understandably, he had developed a very strong dislike for Germans. Inciden- tal y, the aeronautical department was headed by a German, Prof. Walter Repenthin. Another wel -known professor, Dr Kurt Tank, was a distinguished aeronautical engineer who had designed the German Focke–Wulf FW 190 single-seater fighter plane, an outstanding combat aircraft of the Second World War. Dr Tank later joined the Hindustan Aeronautics Limited (HAL) in Bangalore and was responsible for the design of India's first jet fighter, the HF-24 Marut.

Notwithstanding these irritants, Prof.